

Cybersecurity & Data Privacy Artifact Library

Twelve realistic district documents showing what a K-12 technology leader should have ready before, during, and after a cybersecurity incident—from intake and Texas reporting decisions to communications, vendor review, risk governance, and sensitive-data handling.

Use as models, not plug-and-play legal forms. Each artifact should be localized to board policy, district procedures, cyber-insurance requirements, and current advice of district legal counsel. The legal-reference flow was checked against current public Texas sources in August 2026.

Artifact Set

1

Cybersecurity Incident Response Plan

Leadership, technical response, communications, legal, insurance, and recovery responsibilities

Web View

Markdown

PDF

2

First 24/48 Hours Cyber Incident Checklist

Printable leadership checklist for the first two days of a major cybersecurity incident

Web View

Markdown

PDF

3

Cyber Incident Intake and Triage Form

Standardized intake, evidence preservation, severity assessment, and escalation record

Web View

Markdown

PDF

4

Texas Cyber Incident Reporting and Breach Notification Decision Matrix

Leadership decision aid for overlapping Texas reporting and notification duties

[Web View](#)[Markdown](#)[PDF](#)

5

Parent/Guardian Student Data Breach Notification

Plain-language sample notification for a reportable incident involving student information

[Web View](#)[Markdown](#)[PDF](#)

6

Employee or Other Affected Individual Breach Notification

Sample Texas Chapter 521 notice for sensitive personal information

[Web View](#)[Markdown](#)[PDF](#)

7

Cyber Incident Executive Brief for Superintendent and Board

One- to two-page leadership status brief that separates facts, risk, decisions, and next steps

[Web View](#)[Markdown](#)[PDF](#)

8

Cyber Incident Communications Packet

Ready-to-adapt internal, family, website, media, board, and recovery messages

[Web View](#)[Markdown](#)[PDF](#)

9

Cybersecurity Incident Quick Runbooks

Seven scenario-specific response cards for common K-12 incidents

[Web View](#)[Markdown](#)[PDF](#)

10

Vendor Security and Student Data Privacy Review Packet

Pre-procurement risk review for K-12 software, cloud, AI-enabled tools, and service providers

[Web View](#)[Markdown](#)[PDF](#)

11

Cybersecurity Risk Register and Improvement Plan

Prioritized leadership view of cyber risk aligned to NIST CSF 2.0

[Web View](#)[Markdown](#)[PDF](#)

12

Sensitive Data Classification, Handling, and Encryption Standard

Practical district standard for storing, sharing, transmitting, and disposing of sensitive information

[Web View](#)[Markdown](#)[PDF](#)

How the Documents Work Together

Incident Intake (3) → Incident Response Plan (1) + 24/48-Hour Checklist (2) → Texas Decision Matrix (4) → Executive Brief (7) + Communications Packet (8) + Notifications (5-6) → Quick Runbooks (9) → Risk Register (11). Vendor review (10) and data handling/encryption (12) reduce the likelihood and impact of future incidents.

District Scenario Used Across the Set

Several artifacts use incident **AISD-IR-2026-004**, a third-party student-support portal compromise affecting 3,240 potentially viewed student records, to demonstrate how a technology director moves from facts to state reporting, parent notice, executive briefing, vendor remediation, and public communication. A separate employee-data example demonstrates Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 notification workflow when Social Security numbers are involved.

Cybersecurity Incident Response Plan

Leadership, technical response, communications, legal, insurance, and recovery responsibilities

OWNER Chief Technology Officer / Cybersecurity Coordinator	DISTRICT Ardent ISD	REVIEW CYCLE Annual + after major incident	POLICY CROSS- REFERENCE CQB FL records-retention procedures
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Training Sample - Customize Before Use. This document is an instructional artifact for Ardent ISD. It should be aligned to current board policy, administrative procedures, cyber-insurance requirements, records-retention requirements, and advice of district legal counsel before operational use. Legal and reporting requirements can change.

1. Purpose

Ardent ISD uses this plan to coordinate a disciplined response to cybersecurity incidents that could disrupt district operations, compromise student or employee information, or damage public trust. The plan is intentionally cross-functional. Cybersecurity incidents are not handled by Technology Services alone.

The district's response objectives are to:

1. protect students, staff, and district operations;
2. contain the incident without destroying evidence;
3. preserve reliable facts for technical, legal, insurance, and law-enforcement review;
4. meet applicable reporting and notification obligations;
5. restore critical services in a controlled order; and
6. document lessons learned and reduce recurrence.

2. Governance and Authority

The Superintendent designates the **Chief Technology Officer as Ardent ISD's Cybersecurity Coordinator**. The coordinator activates this plan when an event may meet the district's incident threshold. Texas Education Code §11.175 requires a district cybersecurity policy, a designated cybersecurity coordinator, and reporting/parent notice in specified student-information incidents. Texas reporting also intersects with Texas Cyber Command requirements and Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521. Legal counsel determines the district's legal obligations in a specific event.

Core Incident Leadership Team

Role	Primary responsibility during incident
Superintendent - Dr. Elena Ramirez	Executive authority; board coordination; continuity decisions
CTO / Cybersecurity Coordinator - Morgan Lee	Incident lead; technical coordination; state cyber reporting liaison
District General Counsel	Privilege strategy; legal analysis; notification obligations; law-enforcement coordination
Chief Communications Officer - Avery Brooks	Internal/external communications; family/media messaging; rumor control
CFO / Risk Management - Priya Shah	Cyber-insurance notice; financial controls; emergency procurement
Chief HR Officer - Cameron Ortiz	Employee impact; workforce communication; identity protection coordination
Student Services / Privacy Lead	Student-record impact; family support; FERPA/Texas student privacy coordination
Records Management Officer	Legal hold, records preservation, public-information coordination
External IR / Forensics	Evidence collection, scoping, containment and recovery support as authorized

Backups and contact information are maintained in a protected offline contact sheet. At least two members of the incident team shall have access when district systems are unavailable.

3. Incident Severity Levels

Level	Description	Typical examples	Activation
1 - Event	Suspicious activity with no confirmed compromise or material disruption	blocked phishing attempt; malware quarantined on one device	Technology Services handles; document as needed
2 - Limited Incident	Confirmed compromise with contained scope and limited operational/data impact	compromised user account; lost encrypted device; small unauthorized disclosure	CTO activates limited team; counsel notified when protected data may be involved
3 - Major Incident	Significant compromise, protected-data exposure, multi-system impact, or material service disruption	ransomware in one business system; admin-account takeover; vendor breach affecting district data	Full incident team; insurer and external IR considered immediately
4 - Crisis	Districtwide or safety/continuity impact; widespread data exposure; active extortion	enterprise ransomware; SIS/ERP outage during critical operations; large exfiltration	Superintendent-led crisis structure; full continuity and communications plan

Severity may increase or decrease as evidence changes.

4. Activation and First Actions

When a suspected incident is reported:

1. **Open an incident record** using Artifact 3, *Cyber Incident Intake and Triage Form*.
2. **Validate and scope** before declaring facts. Preserve logs, messages, alerts, and relevant system state.

3. **Contain without destroying evidence.** Isolate affected accounts, devices, or segments as appropriate; avoid wiping or reimaging until the incident lead/forensics team authorizes it.
4. **Protect backups and privileged access.** Confirm backup isolation and review administrative-account activity.
5. **Notify the incident leadership team** based on severity.
6. **Contact cyber insurer/breach counsel** according to policy before retaining outside vendors when coverage terms require it.
7. **Start the legal/reporting clock log** using Artifact 4. Document *discovery*, *determination*, *eradication*, *closure*, and *recovery* dates separately.
8. **Establish a source of truth.** Technical facts go to the incident lead; public-facing facts go through Communications and legal review.

Do not: wipe affected systems, destroy logs, negotiate with an extortion actor, promise that “no data was accessed,” or send public notices before facts and legal obligations have been reviewed.

5. Response Lifecycle

A. Detect and Analyze

- Confirm whether the alert is an event, incident, or suspected breach.
- Identify affected systems, identities, data sets, campuses, vendors, and business processes.
- Determine earliest known malicious activity and likely initial access.
- Determine whether privileged accounts, backups, student records, employee records, financial systems, safety systems, or communications platforms are affected.
- Create an evidence register with source, collector, date/time, and storage location.
- Use NIST CSF 2.0 as a shared vocabulary: **Govern, Identify, Protect, Detect, Respond, Recover.**

B. Contain

Containment decisions should balance stopping harm against preserving evidence and maintaining school operations. Examples include disabling compromised accounts, revoking sessions/tokens, blocking indicators, isolating devices or VLANs, limiting vendor connectivity, and temporarily disabling high-risk integrations.

C. Eradicate

Remove malicious persistence, reset credentials in a controlled sequence, patch exploited vulnerabilities, rotate keys/tokens, remove unauthorized applications, and validate that attacker access has been removed.

D. Recover

Prioritize recovery based on learning and operational impact:

1. identity, authentication, DNS, core network and security controls;
2. safety, communications, payroll/finance and student information systems;
3. instructional platforms and campus services;
4. lower-priority services.

Restored systems should be monitored for recurrence. Backups must be tested before restoration and scanned/validated before being trusted.

E. Close and Improve

Closure requires technical recovery **and** leadership closure. The team documents:

- what happened and what remains uncertain;
- what data/systems were affected;
- all notifications and reports made;
- recovery milestones and residual risk;
- costs and insurance activity;
- control failures and corrective actions;
- policy/procedure changes;
- lessons for the next tabletop exercise.

Update Artifact 11, *Cybersecurity Risk Register and Improvement Plan*.

6. Reporting and Notification

Use Artifact 4 for the operational decision flow. As of this library's August 2026 review:

- Texas Cyber Command states that the same statutory incident-reporting deadlines apply to school districts and charter schools: reporting within **48 hours of discovery** when the incident is reportable, with reporting within 24 hours strongly encouraged, and a follow-up analysis by the **10th business day after eradication, closure, and recovery**.
- Texas Education Code §11.175 requires district reporting as soon as practicable for specified cyberattacks/cybersecurity incidents constituting a breach of system security and requires parental notice when the reportable incident involves a student's information.
- Texas Business & Commerce Code §521.053 can require notice to affected individuals without unreasonable delay and generally no later than the **60th day after the district determines that the breach occurred**; if at least **250 Texas residents** are involved, electronic notice to the Texas Attorney General is required as soon as practicable and no later than the **30th day after determination**.

District General Counsel validates which statutes, contracts, insurance provisions, and federal privacy rules apply to the facts of each incident.

7. Communications Rules

- Communications owns public messaging; Technology Services provides verified technical facts.
- Use an initial holding statement when facts are incomplete.
- State what is known, what is being investigated, what stakeholders need to do, and when the next update will occur.
- Do not speculate about threat actor identity, ransom amount, data exfiltration, or root cause.
- Use Artifact 8, *Cyber Incident Communications Packet*.

8. Vendor Incidents

When a vendor reports an incident:

- obtain incident number, discovery date/time, data types, affected records, attack window, controls involved, containment status, and expected update cadence;
- preserve the vendor's notification and contract/DPA;
- determine whether the vendor is the data owner or merely maintains district data for purposes of Texas notice obligations;
- review contractual notification timelines and cooperation requirements;
- consider disabling integrations or credentials until risk is understood;
- do not assume the vendor's statement resolves Ardent ISD's independent legal duties.

9. Exercises and Maintenance

Ardent ISD will conduct at least one cross-functional tabletop exercise annually and after major changes to identity, backup, SIS/ERP, network, or incident-response vendors. The plan is reviewed annually and after every Level 3 or Level 4 incident.

Suggested exercise evidence:

- 24/48-hour checklist completion;
- contact-tree test;
- sample TXCC/OAG decision matrix;
- draft board/family communication;
- restore test from protected backup;
- after-action report with assigned remediation owners.

Related Artifacts

- Artifact 2 - First 24/48 Hours Cyber Incident Checklist
- Artifact 3 - Cyber Incident Intake and Triage Form
- Artifact 4 - Texas Cyber Incident Reporting and Breach Notification Decision Matrix
- Artifact 7 - Cyber Incident Executive Brief
- Artifact 8 - Cyber Incident Communications Packet
- Artifact 9 - Cybersecurity Incident Quick Runbooks
- Artifact 11 - Cybersecurity Risk Register and Improvement Plan

Authority and Reference Notes

- Texas Education Code § 11.175 - School Cybersecurity
- Texas Government Code Chapter 2063 - Texas Cyber Command (see § 2063.302)
- Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 - Identity Theft Enforcement and Protection Act
- Texas Cyber Command - Report a Cybersecurity Incident
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Texas Requirements

- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Security Breach Notification and Response
- NIST Cybersecurity Framework 2.0
- CISA - Protecting Our Future: Cybersecurity for K-12
- CISA - #StopRansomware Guide
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Breach Response Checklist
- K12 SIX - Cybersecurity Essentials Series and Incident Response Runbook

First 24/48 Hours Cyber Incident Checklist

Printable leadership checklist for the first two days of a major cybersecurity incident

OWNER CTO / Cybersecurity Coordinator	DISTRICT Ardent ISD	REVIEW CYCLE Annual + after major incident	POLICY CROSS-REFERENCE CQB Incident Response Plan
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Print and store an offline copy. During a serious incident, email, cloud storage, SSO, phones, and district websites may be unavailable or untrusted.

Incident Header

Field	Entry
Incident ID	
Discovery date/time	
Incident lead	
Initial severity	☐ 1 Event ☐ 2 Limited ☐ 3 Major ☐ 4 Crisis
Systems/data suspected	
Next executive update	

0-2 Hours: Validate, Stabilize, Preserve

- ☐ Open Artifact 3 incident intake/triage record and assign an incident ID.
- ☐ Confirm a trusted communications channel for the incident team.
- ☐ Preserve the original alert, email, screenshot, logs, and relevant timestamps.
- ☐ Identify affected accounts, devices, applications, networks, vendors, and data.
- ☐ Isolate affected systems/accounts when doing so will reduce harm.

- ☐ Do not wipe, reimage, factory-reset, or discard potentially relevant devices/logs.
- ☐ Protect backup systems and administrative accounts from the same compromise.
- ☐ Notify CTO/Cybersecurity Coordinator and Superintendent based on severity.
- ☐ Notify District General Counsel when protected data, extortion, law enforcement, or public notice may be involved.
- ☐ Notify cyber insurer/breach coach according to policy requirements.

2-6 Hours: Scope and Coordinate

- ☐ Activate the cross-functional incident team for Level 3-4 events.
- ☐ Establish incident objectives for the next operational period: contain, preserve, understand, communicate, recover.
- ☐ Start a written decision log: decision, owner, time, rationale.
- ☐ Record the legal clock dates separately: discovery date; determination-of-breach date; eradication; closure; recovery.
- ☐ Identify likely critical-service impacts: safety, internet, identity, SIS, ERP/payroll, transportation, phones, websites, learning systems.
- ☐ Determine whether a third-party vendor is involved and preserve the contract/DPA.
- ☐ Determine whether law enforcement or external forensic support is appropriate.
- ☐ Prepare a short internal holding statement for staff leaders; do not overstate facts.

6-24 Hours: Reporting, Containment, Continuity

- ☐ Use Artifact 4 to evaluate Texas Cyber Command, Education Code, OAG, parent, employee, insurer, and contractual notices.
- ☐ If reportable to Texas Cyber Command, report as soon as possible; the current state page strongly encourages within 24 hours and states a 48-hour statutory deadline.
- ☐ Confirm who is authorized to communicate with TXCC, TEA/state systems, OAG, law enforcement, insurer, vendors, and media.
- ☐ Implement short-term containment: account lockout, token revocation, firewall/DNS blocks, vendor access suspension, segment isolation, or other approved measures.
- ☐ Verify whether backups are isolated, recent, readable, and not obviously affected.
- ☐ Identify manual workarounds for critical school operations.
- ☐ Prepare executive brief (Artifact 7) with known facts, unknowns, risks, decisions needed, and next update time.
- ☐ Prepare public/family communications only if needed and after legal review.

24-48 Hours: Deepen Scope and Build Recovery Plan

- ☐ Confirm incident timeline and earliest known malicious activity.
- ☐ Identify all compromised credentials and privileged accounts.
- ☐ Confirm data categories potentially viewed, copied, altered, encrypted, or exfiltrated.
- ☐ Establish recovery sequence and validation criteria for each critical service.

- ☐ Draft any legally required individual, parent, employee, or regulator notices using Artifacts 5-6 and legal review.
- ☐ Set a recurring executive/board update cadence.
- ☐ Track direct costs, vendor time, overtime, replacement equipment, identity protection, and insurance claim numbers.
- ☐ Preserve evidence and records under direction of counsel/records management.
- ☐ Document unresolved questions and assign owners.
- ☐ Schedule the first after-action review date, even if recovery will continue for weeks.

Escalate Immediately If Any of These Are True

Escalation triggers: ransomware/extortion; confirmed data exfiltration; privileged/admin account compromise; backup compromise; districtwide authentication outage; SIS/ERP/payroll interruption; safety-system impact; active fraud/wire-transfer attempt; media contact; threat actor contact; student health/special education records involved; Social Security numbers or financial credentials involved.

Quick Texas Clock Card

ASAP / 24h preferred

State cyber reporting when applicable; current TXCC guidance strongly encourages reporting within 24 hours.

48 hours

Current TXCC page states statutory reporting deadline for covered incidents affecting school districts/ local governments.

30 days

Texas AG notice for a Chapter 521 breach involving at least 250 Texas residents, measured from determination that a breach occurred.

60 days

General outer deadline for affected-person notice under Texas B&C §521.053, subject to statutory exceptions and counsel review.

Post-recovery: TXCC's current guidance states the follow-up cause analysis is due by the **10th business day after eradication, closure, and recovery** for reportable incidents.

References

- Texas Cyber Command - Report a Cybersecurity Incident
- Texas Government Code Chapter 2063 - Texas Cyber Command (see § 2063.302)
- Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 - Identity Theft Enforcement and Protection Act
- Texas Education Code § 11.175 - School Cybersecurity
- CISA - #StopRansomware Guide
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Breach Response Checklist

Cyber Incident Intake and Triage Form

Standardized intake, evidence preservation, severity assessment, and escalation record

OWNER
Technology Service Desk / Security Operations

DISTRICT
Ardent ISD

REVIEW CYCLE
Annual + after major incident

POLICY CROSS-REFERENCE
Incident Response Plan

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A. Intake Information

Field	Entry
Incident ID	AISD-IR-_____
Date/time reported	_____
Date/time first observed	_____
Reporter name/role	_____
Contact method	_____
Campus/department	_____
Received by	_____

B. What Was Observed?

Reporter description (use the reporter's words):

Indicators Observed

- ☐ Unexpected login / MFA prompt
- ☐ Account lockout or password reset not initiated by user
- ☐ Phishing or suspicious email

- ☐ Malware/endpoint security alert
- ☐ Files renamed, encrypted, deleted, or inaccessible
- ☐ Unusual network or application behavior
- ☐ Unauthorized data access or disclosure
- ☐ Lost or stolen device/media
- ☐ Vendor notification
- ☐ Website/service unavailable or DDoS suspected
- ☐ Fraudulent payment / banking change request
- ☐ Threat actor/extortion message
- ☐ Other: _____

C. Systems and Identities Potentially Affected

Area	Suspected/Confirmed	Notes
User account(s)	☐ Suspected ☐ Confirmed ☐ No	
Privileged/admin account	☐ Suspected ☐ Confirmed ☐ No	
Endpoint/device	☐ Suspected ☐ Confirmed ☐ No	
Server/network	☐ Suspected ☐ Confirmed ☐ No	
Cloud/SaaS	☐ Suspected ☐ Confirmed ☐ No	
Student information system	☐ Suspected ☐ Confirmed ☐ No	
ERP/payroll/finance	☐ Suspected ☐ Confirmed ☐ No	
Safety/communications	☐ Suspected ☐ Confirmed ☐ No	
Vendor/third party	☐ Suspected ☐ Confirmed ☐ No	

D. Data Potentially Involved

- ☐ Student education records / FERPA-protected information
- ☐ Special education / disability information
- ☐ Student health or medical information
- ☐ Student identifiers, contact information, grades, assessments
- ☐ Employee personnel records
- ☐ Social Security numbers
- ☐ Driver's license / government ID numbers
- ☐ Financial account or payment information
- ☐ Credentials, password hashes, tokens, API keys
- ☐ Security configurations, vulnerability information, security logs
- ☐ No sensitive/protected data currently identified

☐ Unknown - investigation required

E. Immediate Actions Already Taken

Time	Person	Action	Result

Evidence reminder: Do not wipe/reimage a device, delete the original email, purge logs, or reset all systems reflexively. Preserve evidence while taking proportionate containment actions.

F. Initial Severity Assessment

Question	Yes/No/Unknown
Is there active harm or ongoing attacker access?	
Is a privileged/admin account involved?	
Are multiple systems/campuses affected?	
Is protected student or employee data involved?	
Is critical district operation disrupted?	
Is ransomware/extortion involved?	
Is a vendor involved?	
Is public/media attention likely?	

Initial severity: ☐ Level 1 Event ☐ Level 2 Limited ☐ Level 3 Major ☐ Level 4 Crisis

Escalated to: ☐ CTO ☐ Superintendent ☐ Legal ☐ Communications ☐ Risk/Insurance ☐ HR ☐ Student Services/Privacy ☐ External IR

Next review time: _____

G. Evidence Register

Evidence ID	Description	Source	Collected by	Date/time	Protected location
E-001					
E-002					
E-003					

H. Legal/Reporting Clock Fields

These dates are not interchangeable. Counsel should validate which date controls each legal obligation.

Event	Date/time	Basis/notes
Incident discovered		
Breach determined		
TXCC report submitted		Incident/confirmation #:
Eradication completed		
Incident closed		
Recovery completed		
Follow-up analysis submitted		
OAG notice submitted, if applicable		
Parent/affected-person notices sent		

References

- U.S. Department of Education - Data Breach Response Checklist
- Texas Cyber Command - Report a Cybersecurity Incident
- Texas Education Code § 11.175 - School Cybersecurity
- Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 - Identity Theft Enforcement and Protection Act

Texas Cyber Incident Reporting and Breach Notification Decision Matrix

Leadership decision aid for overlapping Texas reporting and notification duties

OWNER Cybersecurity Coordinator + District General Counsel	DISTRICT Ardent ISD	REVIEW CYCLE Annual + after major incident	POLICY CROSS-REFERENCE CQB Incident Response Plan FL
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Use This Matrix With Legal Counsel

Texas school districts can face **overlapping but different** reporting duties. An incident may trigger one law and not another. The district should document its reasoning even when counsel determines that a particular notice is not required.

Decision Flow

Step 1 - Is there a cybersecurity incident?

Examples: suspected or confirmed unauthorized access, ransomware, compromised account, unauthorized data disclosure/modification, malicious service disruption, or security incident involving a vendor that maintains district data.

- **No:** document and close as a security event if appropriate.
- **Yes/Unknown:** open an incident record and continue.

Step 2 - Does Texas Education Code §11.175 apply?

Ask:

1. Was there a cyberattack or other cybersecurity incident against district cyberinfrastructure?
2. Did it constitute a **breach of system security** under §11.175 - meaning student information that is sensitive, protected, or confidential under state/federal law was stolen, copied, transmitted, viewed, or used by an unauthorized person?

If **yes**, the statute requires district reporting as soon as practicable using the state-coordinated system, and the Cybersecurity Coordinator must provide notice to a parent/person standing in parental relation when the reportable incident involves the student's information.

Ardent ISD action: Cybersecurity Coordinator + counsel document report date, parent-notice plan, affected student population, and exact information involved.

Step 3 - Does Texas Cyber Command reporting apply?

Current Texas Cyber Command guidance says the statutory reporting deadlines apply to school districts and charter schools. For reportable incidents, the state currently lists:

- **Recommended:** report within 24 hours of discovery;
- **Required:** report within 48 hours of discovery;
- **Required follow-up:** submit incident details/cause analysis by the 10th business day after eradication, closure, and recovery.

Current TXCC guidance describes reportable incidents as including incidents assessed to propagate to other systems, result in criminal violations that must be reported to law enforcement, or involve unauthorized disclosure/modification of confidential information. When facts are uncertain, Ardent ISD will contact TXCC and counsel rather than wait for perfect information.

Step 4 - Does Texas Business & Commerce Code §521.053 apply?

Ask whether there was unauthorized acquisition of computerized data that compromises the security, confidentiality, or integrity of **sensitive personal information (SPI)** as defined in Chapter 521.

Examples of SPI include certain unencrypted combinations of name + SSN, driver's license/government ID, or financial account credentials, and individually identifying health-care information.

If Chapter 521 applies:

- affected individuals must generally be notified **without unreasonable delay and no later than the 60th day after the district determines that the breach occurred**, subject to statutory exceptions/delay provisions;
- a district or other person that maintains SPI it does not own must notify the owner/license holder immediately after discovering the breach;
- if the breach involves **at least 250 Texas residents**, OAG notice must be submitted electronically **as soon as practicable and no later than the 30th day after the district determines that the breach occurred**.

Encryption nuance: Under §521.002, some name-plus-identifier combinations are defined as SPI only when not encrypted. But §521.053's breach definition expressly includes encrypted data if the unauthorized person also has the decryption key. Do not assume "encrypted" automatically eliminates every reporting or notification duty.

Step 5 - What other duties may apply?

Source	Questions to ask
FERPA / Student Privacy Policy Office	Is PII from education records involved? Was disclosure authorized? What mitigation/parent communication is appropriate? FERPA does not prescribe a single set of technical security controls.
Texas Education Code Chapter 32 / Texas Student Privacy Act	Did an operator of a school-purpose online service expose "covered information"? What does the contract require? Is deletion, use, disclosure, or reasonable-security language relevant?
COPPA	For under-13 services, was school consent used within the educational context? Is the vendor using data for any non-school commercial purpose?
Contract / DPA	What is the vendor's incident-notification deadline? Cooperation, deletion, audit, indemnity, security, insurance, and subprocessor duties?
Cyber insurance	Does the policy require notice through a hotline, use of panel counsel/forensics, or approval before costs are incurred?
Law enforcement	Is there fraud, extortion, unauthorized access, theft, or other criminal activity? Who coordinates with TXCC/FBI/local law enforcement?
Public Information / Records	What records must be preserved? What cyber-vulnerability/log information may be confidential under law? Coordinate with records officer/counsel.

Sample Decision Log: AISD-IR-2026-004

Facts: On March 3, 2026, Ardent ISD learned that a vendor support account was used without authorization to access the Student Success Portal. Investigation identified 3,240 potentially viewed student records containing names, district IDs, campuses, grade levels, guardian email addresses, and program-participation flags. No SSNs, financial information, passwords, or health records were stored in the affected portal.

Question	Sample determination
Education Code §11.175?	Yes - protected/confidential student information was potentially viewed without authorization. Report/parent notice required; counsel validates.
TXCC?	Yes / report promptly - unauthorized access to confidential district information; Ardent reported within 24 hours.
B&C Chapter 521 consumer notice?	Not triggered on currently known data types in this sample; counsel documented the analysis.
OAG 250+ notice?	No, based on the same Chapter 521 analysis in this sample.
FERPA/privacy response?	Yes - investigate, mitigate, document, and communicate appropriately.
Vendor contract?	Yes - enforce incident cooperation and remediation terms.

The purpose of this sample is to show why **student privacy notice duties and Chapter 521 consumer-breach duties are not identical**.

Deadline Tracking Table

Requirement	Trigger	Sample deadline field	Owner
TXCC initial report	Reportable incident discovered	Discovery + 48 hours maximum under current TXCC guidance	Cybersecurity Coordinator
Education Code report	§11.175 breach of system security	As soon as practicable	Cybersecurity Coordinator
Parent notice	Reportable §11.175 incident involving student information	Counsel determines timing/content	Cybersecurity Coordinator + Communications
Texas AG	Chapter 521 breach involving 250+ Texas residents	Determination + 30 days maximum	Legal/Risk
Affected individuals	Chapter 521 breach	Without unreasonable delay; generally determination + 60 days maximum	Legal/Communications
TXCC follow-up	After eradication, closure, and recovery	10th business day after those milestones	Cybersecurity Coordinator

TASB/TASA Alignment Note

TASB's public materials identify **CQB - Technology Resources: Cybersecurity** as the policy area for district cybersecurity and separately maintain member guidance on Texas cybersecurity requirements and breach response. TASB also advises districts to keep board policy, administrative procedures, handbooks, and implementation practices aligned. TASA and TASB's school-mandates work treats cybersecurity/data-breach requirements as operational obligations school leaders must plan and budget for.

References

- Texas Education Code § 11.175 - School Cybersecurity
- Texas Government Code Chapter 2063 - Texas Cyber Command (see § 2063.302)
- Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 - Identity Theft Enforcement and Protection Act
- Texas Education Code Chapter 32 - Student Information Protection
- Texas Cyber Command - Report a Cybersecurity Incident
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Texas Requirements
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Security Breach Notification and Response
- TASA/TASB - Report on School District Mandates
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Security: K-12 and Higher Education
- Federal Trade Commission - COPPA FAQ: COPPA and Schools

Parent/Guardian Student Data Breach Notification

Plain-language sample notification for a reportable incident involving student information

OWNER
Cybersecurity Coordinator
+ Communications + Legal

DISTRICT
Ardent ISD

REVIEW CYCLE
Annual + after major incident

POLICY CROSS-REFERENCE

CQB FL

Incident Response Plan

Training Sample - Customize Before Use. This document is an instructional artifact for Ardent ISD. It should be aligned to current board policy, administrative procedures, cyber-insurance requirements, records-retention requirements, and advice of district legal counsel before operational use. Legal and reporting requirements can change.

Sample Notice - AISD-IR-2026-004

Date: March 12, 2026
To: Parent/Guardian of an Ardent ISD Student
Subject: Notice of Cybersecurity Incident Involving Student Information

Dear Parent or Guardian,

Ardent ISD is writing to inform you about a cybersecurity incident involving a third-party student support platform used by the district. We take the privacy and security of student information seriously, and we want to explain what occurred, what information may have been involved, and what we are doing in response.

What happened

On March 3, 2026, the district was notified that an unauthorized person had used a vendor support account to access the Student Success Portal. The vendor disabled the account, and Ardent ISD began an investigation with cybersecurity and legal support. The investigation identified unauthorized access activity between February 27 and March 2, 2026.

What information was involved

Based on the information available as of the date of this letter, the affected portal contained the following information for your student:

- student name;
- district student identification number;
- campus and grade level;

- parent/guardian email address; and
- limited program-participation information used to support student services.

The affected portal **did not contain Social Security numbers, financial account information, district passwords, or student health records.**

What Ardent ISD has done

Ardent ISD has:

- disabled the affected vendor access path and reviewed related credentials;
- preserved relevant logs and records for investigation;
- reported the incident through applicable Texas cybersecurity reporting channels;
- required the vendor to provide additional security information and corrective actions;
- increased monitoring of the affected service; and
- begun a review of vendor access controls and support-account practices across other district systems.

What you need to do

At this time, we are not asking you or your student to change a district password because district credentials were not stored in the affected portal. As a general precaution, be alert for messages that use school-related information to create a false sense of urgency. Ardent ISD will never ask a student or parent to send a password through email or text message.

If our investigation identifies additional information that changes the steps you should take, we will contact you.

Questions

A current incident FAQ is available through the Ardent ISD family communications page. Families may also contact the district's designated incident support line during published business hours.

We regret the concern this incident may cause. Ardent ISD will continue to provide updates when there is meaningful new information to share.

Sincerely,

Morgan Lee

Chief Technology Officer / Cybersecurity Coordinator
Ardent Independent School District

Customization Checklist Before Sending

- ☐ Legal counsel confirms the notice is required and approves wording.
- ☐ Facts match forensic findings and vendor documentation.
- ☐ Information categories are specific; avoid vague phrases such as “some data.”
- ☐ Do not claim data was “not accessed” unless evidence supports that statement.

- ☐ State whether credentials, SSNs, financial data, health data, special education data, or other high-risk data were involved when known.
- ☐ Include identity/credit monitoring only when appropriate to the data and incident.
- ☐ Provide accessible, multilingual versions appropriate for district families.
- ☐ Coordinate website FAQ, call center, campus leader scripts, and media holding statement.
- ☐ Preserve the final notice, distribution list/method, and date sent in the incident record.

Why This Sample Is Written This Way

The sample separates verified facts from ongoing investigation, explains the specific data categories, states what was *not* present only where the sample facts support it, and gives families a practical action. Texas Education Code §11.175 includes a parent-notice duty for reportable incidents involving student information. The U.S. Department of Education's breach-response guidance recommends adapting notices to the incident and consulting legal counsel.

References

- Texas Education Code § 11.175 - School Cybersecurity
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Breach Response Checklist
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Security: K-12 and Higher Education
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Security Breach Notification and Response

Employee or Other Affected Individual Breach Notification

Sample Texas Chapter 521 notice for sensitive personal information

OWNER Human Resources + Legal + Communications	DISTRICT Ardent ISD	REVIEW CYCLE Annual + after major incident	POLICY CROSS-REFERENCE CQB personnel records Incident Response Plan
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Sample Notice - AISD-IR-2026-007

Date: June 3, 2026
To: Affected Current/Former Employee
Subject: Notice of Data Security Incident

Dear Ardent ISD Employee or Former Employee,

Ardent Independent School District is notifying you of a data security incident that may have involved some of your personal information. This notice explains what happened, the information involved, the steps the district has taken, and actions you may consider.

What happened

On May 18, 2026, Ardent ISD discovered that an external account had gained unauthorized access to a vendor support workspace used during a human-resources data migration. The district immediately restricted access, notified its cybersecurity response partners, and began an investigation.

The investigation determined that a file placed in the workspace for migration troubleshooting was accessible to the unauthorized account for a limited period. The district has no evidence at this time that the information has been used for identity theft, but because the file was accessible, we are notifying affected individuals.

What information was involved

The file contained:

- employee name;

- employee identification number; and
- Social Security number.

The file did **not** contain district passwords, direct-deposit account numbers, or medical/benefit information.

What we are doing

Ardent ISD has:

- removed the file and terminated the unauthorized access path;
- reset and restricted vendor support access;
- engaged cybersecurity and legal response support;
- reported the incident through applicable Texas cybersecurity and data-breach reporting channels;
- begun a review of data-transfer and vendor-support procedures; and
- arranged **12 months of identity monitoring and identity restoration support** for affected individuals at no cost. Enrollment instructions are included with this notice.

Steps you can consider

You may wish to monitor financial accounts and credit reports for activity you do not recognize. You may also consider a fraud alert or security freeze with the nationwide consumer reporting agencies. The enclosed identity-monitoring information provides additional instructions and support contacts.

For more information

Please contact the Ardent ISD incident support center using the number provided in your mailed or verified-email notice. Do not send your Social Security number or other sensitive information through ordinary email.

Sincerely,

Cameron Ortiz

Chief Human Resources Officer
Ardent Independent School District

Sample Compliance Record for This Notice

Item	Sample entry
Incident discovered	May 18, 2026
District determined Chapter 521 breach occurred	May 22, 2026
Texas residents affected	486
TXCC initial report	May 19, 2026
Texas AG electronic report	June 1, 2026

Item	Sample entry
Individual notice begins	June 3, 2026
Identity-monitoring period	12 months
Law enforcement	Counsel documents whether engaged

The sample assumes legal counsel determined that Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 applies and that at least 250 Texas residents were affected. Under the current statute, the OAG report must include specified incident information and counts, and individual notice generally must occur without unreasonable delay and no later than 60 days after the breach determination, subject to statutory exceptions.

Customization Checklist

- ☐ Use the exact data categories supported by the investigation.
- ☐ Confirm the date of “determination” with legal counsel; do not automatically use discovery date.
- ☐ Confirm Texas resident count and OAG threshold.
- ☐ Coordinate state notices, insurer/breach counsel, and any multi-state notice obligations.
- ☐ Use secure methods for enrollment codes and identity-monitoring details.
- ☐ Provide alternate-language and accessible notices where appropriate.
- ☐ Preserve proof of mailing/email/direct notice.

References

- Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 - Identity Theft Enforcement and Protection Act
- Texas Government Code Chapter 2063 - Texas Cyber Command (see § 2063.302)
- Texas Cyber Command - Report a Cybersecurity Incident
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Security Breach Notification and Response

Cyber Incident Executive Brief for Superintendent and Board

One- to two-page leadership status brief that separates facts, risk, decisions, and next steps

OWNER CTO / Cybersecurity Coordinator	DISTRICT Ardent ISD	REVIEW CYCLE Annual + after major incident	POLICY CROSS- REFERENCE CQB Incident Response Plan
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Executive Brief - AISD-IR-2026-004

Prepared: March 4, 2026, 3:00 PM
Classification: Confidential incident working document - distribution limited to incident leadership team, superintendent, and counsel
Next scheduled update: March 5, 2026, 10:00 AM

Situation in One Sentence

Ardent ISD is investigating unauthorized use of a third-party vendor support account that accessed the Student Success Portal; the access has been contained, 3,240 student records may have been viewed, and no district passwords, Social Security numbers, financial data, or student health records are stored in the affected portal.

What We Know

- Vendor alerted Ardent ISD on **March 3 at 7:42 AM**.
- Unauthorized account activity occurred between **February 27 and March 2**.
- Affected application: Student Success Portal, hosted by a third party.
- Potentially affected records: **3,240 students**.
- Data present: names, district student IDs, campuses, grade levels, guardian emails, limited program-participation flags.
- Vendor support account has been disabled; district integrations have been restricted during review.
- No evidence of malware or ransomware inside Ardent ISD's network has been identified as of this update.

What We Do Not Yet Know

- Whether every accessible student record was actually viewed.
- Whether any information was copied outside the vendor platform.
- The exact method used to compromise the vendor support account.
- Whether other customers of the vendor were affected.

Actions Completed

Action	Status
Incident response plan activated	Complete
Vendor support access disabled	Complete
Relevant logs preserved	Complete
Legal counsel engaged	Complete
Cyber insurer notified	Complete
TXCC report submitted	Complete - within 24 hours in this sample
Parent notice draft prepared	In legal review
Broader vendor access-control review	Started

Legal / Notification Status

Education Code §11.175: Counsel's current sample determination is that the incident is reportable because protected/confidential student information may have been viewed by an unauthorized person; parent notice will be provided.

Texas Cyber Command: Initial incident report submitted. Follow-up cause analysis will be tracked after eradication, closure, and recovery.

Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521: Based on currently identified data types, counsel's sample analysis is that the Chapter 521 sensitive-personal-information breach notice/OAG threshold is not triggered. This will be reevaluated if data scope changes.

Operational Impact

- Instruction: no interruption.
- SIS/gradebook: no interruption.
- Family portal: unaffected.
- Student Success Portal: temporarily restricted for vendor support functions; staff read-only access continues.
- Technology workload: elevated; two staff reassigned to incident support.

Decisions Needed From Superintendent/Cabinet

1. Approve parent notification and FAQ once counsel confirms final content.
2. Authorize temporary suspension of vendor support integrations until remediation evidence is received.
3. Approve external review of privileged third-party access across Tier 1 systems.
4. Confirm board update method: confidential briefing through counsel plus public summary if/when parent notice is released.

Board-Level Message

The district has contained unauthorized third-party access to a student-support platform. The investigation is active. Student learning systems remain operational. We are following state reporting requirements, working with counsel and cybersecurity partners, and will notify affected families with verified information.

Next 24 Hours

- validate vendor forensic timeline;
- finalize affected-student list;
- complete parent notice and FAQ;
- evaluate vendor privileged access across SIS, ERP, SSO, and learning systems;
- establish remediation requirements before full vendor access is restored.

References

- Texas Education Code § 11.175 - School Cybersecurity
- Texas Cyber Command - Report a Cybersecurity Incident
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Security Breach Notification and Response
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Breach Response Checklist

Cyber Incident Communications Packet

Ready-to-adapt internal, family, website, media, board, and recovery messages

OWNER Chief Communications Officer + Legal + Cybersecurity Coordinator	DISTRICT Ardent ISD	REVIEW CYCLE Annual + after major incident	POLICY CROSS- REFERENCE Incident Response Plan CQB
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Communications Operating Rules

- One source of truth:** Incident Lead validates technical facts; Legal validates legal statements; Communications owns publication.
- Say what is known, unknown, and being done.** Avoid speculation.
- Use the least technical language that remains accurate.**
- Never publish security details that would create additional risk.**
- Set the next-update expectation.** Silence invites rumor.
- Keep versions.** Preserve every published statement and approval record.

A. Initial Staff Leadership Alert

Subject: Cybersecurity Incident - Leadership Awareness

Ardent ISD is responding to a cybersecurity incident involving **[system/vendor]** discovered at **[date/time]**. Technology Services has **[contained/restricted/isolated]** the affected service and is working with district leadership, legal counsel, and cybersecurity partners.

At this time, **[brief verified operational impact]**. Staff should continue normal operations except for **[specific instruction]**.

Please do not speculate about the incident or share screenshots, logs, or unverified information. Direct media or public inquiries to Communications. Report any related suspicious activity to **[internal reporting channel]**.

Next leadership update: **[date/time]**.

B. Districtwide Staff Notice

Subject: Important Technology Security Update

Ardent ISD is investigating a cybersecurity incident involving **[service]**. We have taken steps to contain the issue and are working with appropriate cybersecurity and legal resources.

What staff need to do now:

- **[Action 1: e.g., do not use service until notified]**
- **[Action 2: e.g., complete password reset through official portal]**
- **[Action 3: report unexpected MFA prompts or suspicious messages]**

Do not send passwords, student information, screenshots of security tools, or incident details through ordinary email or public AI tools.

We will provide another update by **[date/time]**.

C. Family Holding Statement

Ardent ISD is investigating a cybersecurity incident involving **[system/vendor]**. The district has taken steps to contain the incident and is working with cybersecurity and legal professionals to determine the scope. **[Instructional/operational status]**.

If our investigation shows that a student's information was involved in a way that requires notification, the district will contact affected families directly with verified details and recommended next steps. Updates will be posted at **[district incident page]**.

D. Website Notice

Cybersecurity Incident Update - [Date]

Ardent ISD is responding to a cybersecurity incident discovered on **[date]** involving **[service]**. The district has contained **[known condition]** and continues to investigate.

Current service impact: [plain-language status]

Information impact: [known data categories, or "under investigation"]

What families/staff should do: [specific action or "no action requested at this time"]

Next update: [date/time]

The district will update this page when there is meaningful new information.

E. Media Holding Statement

Ardent ISD is responding to a cybersecurity incident involving **[system]**. We have taken containment steps and are working with cybersecurity professionals and legal counsel. Our priority is protecting students, staff, and continuity of district operations. Because the investigation is active, we will not speculate about cause or scope. We will share verified information when appropriate and will make required notifications.

Media Q&A Guardrails

Question	Recommended approach
Was this ransomware?	Answer only when confirmed. If unknown: "The investigation is ongoing; we are not characterizing the incident beyond verified facts."
Was data stolen?	Distinguish "accessible/viewed/copied/exfiltrated" only when evidence supports the term.
Who attacked you?	Do not attribute unless law enforcement/forensics has validated and leadership authorizes.
Did you pay a ransom?	Refer to superintendent/legal; do not answer casually.
Why wasn't this prevented?	Explain layered risk management and current remediation; do not blame an employee/vendor before review.
How many people are affected?	Use validated count and clarify whether "potentially affected" or confirmed.

F. Board Update Email

Subject: Confidential Cyber Incident Update - AISD-IR-[ID]

Board Members,

Ardent ISD is responding to a cybersecurity incident discovered **[date/time]**. Current verified facts:

- affected service(s): [];
- operational impact: [];
- data impact: [];
- containment status: [];
- outside partners engaged: [];
- required notifications: [].

The administration's immediate priorities are **[containment, legal reporting, continuity, recovery]**. The next update will be provided **[date/time]**. Please direct external inquiries to the Superintendent/Communications so the district can provide consistent, verified information.

G. All-Clear / Recovery Message

Ardent ISD has restored **[service]** following the cybersecurity incident first reported on **[date]**. The district has completed the immediate containment and recovery work required to return the service to normal operation. Additional security improvements and post-incident review will continue.

What changed:

- [control/remediation];
- [user action];
- [vendor/system change].

Thank you for following district instructions during the response. Staff should report any unusual activity through the normal technology support/security channel.

H. Parent FAQ - AISD-IR-2026-004 Sample

Was my child's password exposed?

No. In this sample incident, the affected portal did not store district passwords.

Was my child's Social Security number exposed?

No. The affected portal did not contain Social Security numbers.

Why are you notifying me?

The district's investigation found that protected student information may have been viewed by an unauthorized person. Ardent ISD is providing notice consistent with its obligations and commitment to transparency.

Do I need to freeze my child's credit?

Based on the sample data involved, the district is not recommending that step at this time. If the investigation changes the risk assessment, the district will update families.

Why can't you tell us exactly who did it?

Attribution requires reliable evidence and may involve law enforcement. Publishing speculation can interfere with the investigation and create misinformation.

Approval Record

Version	Date/time	Technical fact check	Legal review	Communications approval	Published where
1.0					
1.1					

References

- CISA - #StopRansomware Guide
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Breach Response Checklist
- Texas Education Code § 11.175 - School Cybersecurity
- Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 - Identity Theft Enforcement and Protection Act
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Security Breach Notification and Response

Cybersecurity Incident Quick Runbooks

Seven scenario-specific response cards for common K-12 incidents

OWNER Technology Services / Incident Response Team	DISTRICT Ardent ISD	REVIEW CYCLE Annual + after major incident	POLICY CROSS- REFERENCE Incident Response Plan
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These runbooks support the Incident Response Plan; they do not replace it. When protected data, significant disruption, extortion, fraud, or public notice may be involved, escalate to counsel and district leadership immediately.

Runbook 1 - Ransomware / Data Extortion

Recognize: files encrypted/renamed; ransom note; security tool detects ransomware; attacker threatens data leak.

First actions:

1. isolate impacted systems immediately; if widespread, consider network-level isolation;
2. preserve ransom note, alerts, logs, memory/disk evidence when feasible;
3. disable compromised accounts/tokens and protect privileged identities;
4. protect backups - do not connect backup repositories unnecessarily;
5. activate Level 3/4 incident team, insurer/breach counsel, external IR;
6. use Artifact 4 for TXCC and other reporting decisions;
7. establish continuity plan for critical systems;
8. do not negotiate or pay without superintendent, legal, insurer, and law-enforcement coordination.

Recovery gate: root cause addressed, credentials rotated, malicious persistence removed, backup validated, restored system monitored.

Runbook 2 - Business Email Compromise / Phishing With Account Takeover

Recognize: impossible travel; mailbox rules/forwarding; unusual OAuth app; repeated MFA prompts; sent-mail phishing; invoice/payment changes.

First actions:

- disable or restrict the account;
- revoke sessions/tokens and unauthorized app consent;
- reset credentials from a trusted device;
- review mailbox rules, delegated access, login history, sent/deleted messages;
- determine whether student/employee data was exposed through email/cloud drives;
- contact Finance immediately if payment/banking instructions were involved;
- identify recipients of malicious messages and contain spread.

Runbook 3 - Compromised Administrator / Privileged Account

Recognize: privileged sign-in from unusual source; new admin creation; security settings disabled; mass password resets; new tokens/keys.

First actions:

- use a separate trusted admin account to contain the compromised identity;
- revoke sessions, tokens, keys, and app consents;
- identify every system where the credential has administrative rights;
- review configuration changes and newly created accounts;
- protect backups and identity infrastructure;
- consider resetting related privileged credentials using a controlled sequence;
- escalate to Level 3 because the blast radius may be large even when visible impact is small.

Runbook 4 - Lost or Stolen Device / Portable Media

Recognize: district laptop, phone, USB drive, portable drive, or other media missing.

First actions:

- record device/asset identifier, user, location, time last seen;
- determine encryption status and whether encryption key/credentials may also be compromised;
- remote-lock/wipe **only when consistent with evidence needs and district procedure**;
- disable tokens/certificates/sessions where appropriate;
- identify locally stored student/employee information;
- document whether the device was managed and encrypted;
- use Artifact 4 if protected information may have been acquired.

Encryption matters, but document it. Record the encryption method, management status, key protection, and evidence that encryption was active at the time of loss. Do not simply write “encrypted” with no support.

Runbook 5 - Unauthorized Data Disclosure

Examples: file shared publicly; spreadsheet emailed to wrong recipient; student records attached to wrong message; report link indexed publicly.

First actions:

- remove/restrict access immediately without destroying audit history;
- preserve sharing logs, recipient list, access history, and original file;
- ask unintended recipient to preserve/delete only through counsel-approved process;
- identify exact records and data categories;
- determine whether data was merely sent, actually accessed, downloaded, or further shared;
- evaluate Education Code §11.175, FERPA, Chapter 521, contracts, and parent/affected-person notice.

Runbook 6 - Third-Party Vendor Breach

First actions:

- get written vendor incident notice and incident ID;
- ask: discovery time, compromise window, data types, record count, access/exfiltration evidence, containment, root cause, subprocessors, law enforcement, notification plan;
- preserve contract, DPA, security assessment, and vendor answers;
- rotate/revoke district credentials, API keys, SSO tokens, and integrations as risk warrants;
- determine whether Ardent must make independent notices/reports;
- require remediation evidence before restoring privileged vendor access;
- update vendor risk record in Artifact 10.

Runbook 7 - DDoS / Service Disruption

Recognize: high-volume traffic, service unavailable, provider alert, repeated connection exhaustion.

First actions:

- verify whether outage is malicious versus provider/system failure;
- contact ISP/cloud/DDoS protection provider;
- preserve traffic/monitoring evidence;
- prioritize safety/communications/assessment/instruction continuity;
- use alternate communications if district internet is unavailable;
- determine whether attacker gained access or merely disrupted service;
- assess TXCC reporting with the incident team if reportable criteria are met.

Common Closeout Questions

1. What was the initial access vector?
2. What control should have prevented or limited the incident?
3. What detected it, and how long did detection take?
4. What data and business processes were actually affected?
5. Which decisions were delayed because roles, contacts, or facts were unclear?
6. Were backups, admin accounts, and vendor access appropriately protected?
7. What must change in policy, process, architecture, training, or vendor terms?

References

- CISA - #StopRansomware Guide
- K12 SIX - Cybersecurity Essentials Series and Incident Response Runbook
- Texas Cyber Command - Report a Cybersecurity Incident
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Breach Response Checklist

Vendor Security and Student Data Privacy Review Packet

Pre-procurement risk review for K-12 software, cloud, AI-enabled tools, and service providers

OWNER
Technology + Procurement
+ Privacy + Legal

DISTRICT
Ardent ISD

REVIEW CYCLE
Annual + after major
incident

POLICY CROSS-REFERENCE

CQB FL

procurement
procedures

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Purpose

Ardent ISD uses this packet before a product is approved to receive district student, employee, authentication, financial, or operational data. The packet is modeled on the leadership intent of CoSN's K-12CVAT: vendor review should be a **repeatable procurement risk process**, not an afterthought after implementation.

Part 1 - Intake

Question	Response
Product/service	
Requesting campus/department	
Instructional/operational purpose	
Intended users	☐ Students ☐ Staff ☐ Parents ☐ Public
Student age range	
Data owner/steward	
Contract term / renewal date	
Cost / funding source	
Integrations requested	☐ SSO ☐ SIS ☐ LMS ☐ Rostering ☐ API ☐ Other

Question	Response
AI-enabled functionality	☐ No ☐ Yes - describe

Part 2 - Data Map

What will the vendor receive or create?

- ☐ Student name/contact information
- ☐ District student identifier
- ☐ Grades/assessment data
- ☐ Special education/disability information
- ☐ Health/medical information
- ☐ Discipline/behavior information
- ☐ Student work, messages, audio, images, or video
- ☐ Search/activity telemetry or device identifiers
- ☐ Geolocation
- ☐ Employee personnel information
- ☐ SSN/government ID/financial information
- ☐ District credentials, tokens, directory/group information
- ☐ Security logs/configuration data
- ☐ No personally identifiable/protected data

Data minimization question: What fields can be removed while still meeting the educational/business purpose?

Part 3 - Privacy and Legal Review

Topic	Required vendor answer / reviewer test
FERPA	What education-record PII is received? Under what exception/consent model? Is the provider under district control regarding use/maintenance when relying on the school-official exception?
Texas Student Privacy Act (TEC Chapter 32)	Is the product an operator of a school-purpose online service? Does it maintain reasonable security? How are covered information, disclosure, third parties, deletion, and school-purpose limitations handled?
COPPA	If children under 13 use the service, does vendor rely on school consent? Is data used solely for the school's educational purpose and not a separate commercial purpose?
Parent transparency	What privacy notice can the district provide families? Is data collection understandable?
Data ownership/control	Does Ardent retain ownership/control of district data? Can vendor assert rights inconsistent with district purpose?
Sale/advertising	Is student data sold, used for targeted advertising, or used to build unrelated commercial profiles?
Model/AI training	

Topic	Required vendor answer / reviewer test
	Is district/student data used to train shared/general models? Can that use be disabled contractually and technically?
Deletion	Can Ardent request deletion at contract end and verify completion? Texas law includes deletion requirements for covered information in defined circumstances.

Part 4 - Cybersecurity Review

Baseline Security Questions

1. Does the vendor maintain a documented security program and named security owner?
2. Does the vendor support MFA for administrative/privileged accounts?
3. Is data encrypted in transit and at rest? What happens to encryption keys?
4. How are privileged support accounts approved, logged, and reviewed?
5. Are production and development/test data separated?
6. How frequently are vulnerabilities identified and remediated?
7. Does the vendor conduct independent security assessments (e.g., SOC 2 or equivalent) and provide appropriate evidence under NDA?
8. How are subprocessors identified and controlled?
9. What are backup, disaster recovery, RTO, and RPO commitments?
10. What log/audit evidence will be available to Ardent after an incident?
11. What is the vendor's incident-notification commitment to Ardent (hours, not "without undue delay" alone)?
12. How does the vendor support data export, return, deletion, and account termination?

Part 5 - Incident and Contract Requirements

Ardent ISD prefers contract/DPA language that addresses:

- prompt security-incident notice with a defined time period;
- facts required in each update: discovery time, affected systems/data, record count, containment, known access/exfiltration, subprocessors, law enforcement;
- cooperation with Ardent's legal/regulatory reporting obligations;
- preservation and provision of relevant logs/evidence;
- notification approval/coordination when district data is involved;
- data return/deletion and written certification at termination;
- limits on secondary use, sale, advertising, and non-school-purpose use;
- subprocessor obligations no weaker than the primary agreement;
- cyber insurance where appropriate to risk;
- breach costs/indemnity subject to district counsel and procurement rules;
- right to suspend integration/access during an active incident.

Part 6 - AI-Enabled Tool Questions

If the product includes generative AI, machine learning, automated recommendations, transcription, summarization, or other AI features:

1. Exactly what prompts, files, chats, student work, telemetry, and metadata are retained?
2. Are inputs/outputs used to train shared or future models?
3. Can training/secondary use be contractually and technically disabled?
4. Are prompts/outputs visible to vendor human reviewers?
5. How long are prompts/outputs retained, and can Ardent delete them?
6. What safeguards address minors, harmful content, bias, hallucinations, and inappropriate automated decisions?
7. Can Ardent disable AI features independently from the core service?
8. Are subprocessors/model providers disclosed?
9. What incident-notification obligations apply to the AI provider/subprocessor?

Ardent AI security guardrail: Do not upload real student data, employee data, credentials, security configurations, incident reports, vulnerability findings, or vendor-confidential agreements into a public generative AI service for the purpose of completing this review.

Part 7 - Reviewer Scorecard

Domain	Low risk / acceptable	Needs mitigation	Escalate/reject	Notes
Data sensitivity/minimization	☐	☐	☐	
FERPA/Texas privacy	☐	☐	☐	
COPPA/child privacy	☐	☐	☐	
Security controls	☐	☐	☐	
Incident response	☐	☐	☐	
Subprocessors/data location	☐	☐	☐	
Deletion/exit	☐	☐	☐	
AI/model use	☐	☐	☐	
Contract terms	☐	☐	☐	

Decision: ☐ Approve ☐ Approve with conditions ☐ Pilot with limited data ☐ Escalate to Legal/Security ☐ Reject

Conditions / compensating controls: _____

Re-review date: _____

Sample Mini-Review - SummitLearn Assessment Platform

Purpose: formative assessment and teacher feedback; grades 6-8.

Requested data: student name, district ID, class/teacher, responses, scores.

Initial finding: Vendor supports SSO and encryption, but its standard terms allow broad service-improvement use and provide only “commercially reasonable” incident notice with no time commitment.

Ardent decision: Approve with conditions - execute district DPA; limit data fields; prohibit use for targeted advertising/general model training; require incident notice within contractually defined hours; require annual subprocessor list; verify deletion workflow before production launch.

References

- CoSN - K-12 Community Vendor Assessment Tool (K-12CVAT)
- U.S. Department of Education - Model Terms of Service for Online Educational Services
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Security: K-12 and Higher Education
- Texas Education Code Chapter 32 - Student Information Protection
- Federal Trade Commission - COPPA FAQ: COPPA and Schools
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Texas Requirements

Cybersecurity Risk Register and Improvement Plan

Prioritized leadership view of cyber risk aligned to NIST CSF 2.0

OWNER
CTO / Cybersecurity
Governance Committee

DISTRICT
Ardent ISD

REVIEW CYCLE
Annual + after major
incident

POLICY CROSS-REFERENCE

CQB

strategic technology
plan

budget

Training Sample - Customize Before Use. This document is an instructional artifact for Ardent ISD. It should be aligned to current board policy, administrative procedures, cyber-insurance requirements, records-retention requirements, and advice of district legal counsel before operational use. Legal and reporting requirements can change.

How Ardent ISD Uses This Register

The purpose is not to list every technical weakness. It is to identify **material district risks**, assign ownership, prioritize limited resources, and make progress visible to cabinet and the board. The register uses the NIST CSF 2.0 functions - **Govern, Identify, Protect, Detect, Respond, Recover** - as a common language.

Scoring

- Likelihood: 1 Rare - 5 Likely
- Impact: 1 Low - 5 Severe
- Inherent risk = Likelihood × Impact
- Residual risk = risk remaining after current safeguards

Risk scores support judgment; they do not replace it.

Sample 2026 Ardent ISD Register

ID	NIST	Risk statement	L	I	Inherent	Existing safeguards	Residual	Priority action	Owner	Target
R-01	Protect	Privileged account compromise could enable	4	5	20	MFA; separate admin IDs	12	phishing-resistant MFA for Tier 0 admins;	CTO	Q2

ID	NIST	Risk statement	L	I	Inherent	Existing safeguards	Residual	Priority action	Owner	Target
		broad access across SSO, cloud, and infrastructure						quarterly access review		
R-02	Recover	Backups may not restore critical systems within required time during ransomware	3	5	15	daily backups; offsite copy	10	quarterly restore test for SIS, ERP, identity; immutable copy	Infrastructure	Q2
R-03	Govern	Vendor security/ privacy review is inconsistent across campus purchases	4	4	16	procurement review for major contracts	12	require Artifact 10 for all tools receiving protected data	Procurement + Privacy	Q1
R-04	Identify	District lacks complete inventory of SaaS applications and data owners	4	4	16	SSO app list; finance vendor list	12	build reconciled SaaS/data inventory	CTO + Finance	Q2
R-05	Detect	Cloud account compromise may persist too long before detection	3	5	15	native alerts; endpoint tools	9	centralize identity/ cloud logs; tune high-risk alerts	Security	Q3
R-06	Protect	Legacy service accounts have excessive privileges and non-expiring secrets	4	4	16	partial password vaulting	12	inventory/ rotate; managed identities where feasible	Systems	Q3
R-07	Respond	Incident leadership may lose contact if SSO/email/ VoIP fail together	3	4	12	staff cell directory	8	offline contact tree + quarterly test	CTO + Communications	Q1
R-08	Recover	Recovery order is not agreed across instructional/	3	4	12	DR plan	9	cabinet-approved service	CTO + CFO	Q2

ID	NIST	Risk statement	L	I	Inherent	Existing safeguards	Residual	Priority action	Owner	Target
		business leaders						criticality/ RTO map		
R-09	Protect	Portable exports containing employee SPI could be stored unencrypted	3	5	15	endpoint encryption; policy	8	block unmanaged USB; encrypted transfer workflow; DLP pilot	HR + IT	Q2
R-10	Govern	Staff may place protected data into unapproved generative AI tools	4	4	16	acceptable use guidance	12	approved AI list; data handling training; technical controls	CTO + Curriculum	Q1
R-11	Respond	Vendor breach notices may arrive without enough details to meet district clocks	3	4	12	standard contract clause	8	strengthen DPA incident clause; vendor contact register	Legal + Procurement	Q2
R-12	Protect	MFA fatigue/ social engineering could bypass traditional push-based MFA	4	4	16	MFA required	10	number matching/ stronger factors; targeted training	Security	Q2

Improvement Plan: Top Five Priorities

Priority 1 - Privileged Identity Protection

Outcome: Tier 0/critical administrators use stronger MFA; access reviewed quarterly.

Evidence: access-review log, authentication policy, reduction in standing admin access.

Budget: \$18,000 estimated implementation/keys/training.

Tradeoff: additional administrative friction for a small number of high-risk accounts.

Priority 2 - Tested Recovery

Outcome: Ardent can demonstrate recovery of identity, SIS, ERP, and critical file services from protected backups.

Evidence: quarterly restore test with actual measured RTO/RPO and gaps.

Board message: "We do not call a backup successful until we have restored from it."

Priority 3 - Vendor Governance

Outcome: Any tool receiving protected district data completes the Vendor Security & Privacy Review Packet before procurement/renewal.

Evidence: approval register, renewal dates, data owners, completed reviews, rejected/conditioned vendors.

Priority 4 - SaaS / Data Inventory

Outcome: District can answer “Which vendors hold student or employee data, who owns the relationship, and when does the contract end?”

Evidence: reconciled inventory across SSO, finance, procurement, curriculum, and campus purchasing.

Priority 5 - Incident Communications Resilience

Outcome: Incident team can coordinate even when district SSO/email/VoIP is unavailable.

Evidence: offline contact sheet, alternate conference method, tabletop test results.

Quarterly Cyber Governance Dashboard

Indicator	Target	Current sample	Status
Critical systems with tested restore in last 90 days	100%	75%	Needs work
Tier 0 admins using strongest approved MFA	100%	62%	Needs work
Tier 1 vendors with current risk review	100%	68%	Needs work
Staff cybersecurity training completion	100%	97%	Watch
High-risk findings past target date	0	3	Needs work
Incident tabletop exercises completed this year	1+	1	On track

Governance Review Questions

1. Which residual risks are above the district's tolerance?
2. Which risks need superintendent/board awareness because mitigation requires funding or policy change?
3. Which risks are being accepted, by whom, and until when?
4. What evidence shows that a control works, rather than merely exists?
5. What new risks came from vendor changes, AI adoption, staffing, or infrastructure changes?

References

- NIST Cybersecurity Framework 2.0
- CISA - Protecting Our Future: Cybersecurity for K-12
- K12 SIX - Cybersecurity Essentials Series and Incident Response Runbook
- CoSN - K-12 Community Vendor Assessment Tool (K-12CVAT)
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Texas Requirements

Sensitive Data Classification, Handling, and Encryption Standard

Practical district standard for storing, sharing, transmitting, and disposing of sensitive information

OWNER
CTO + Records
Management + Privacy +
HR

DISTRICT
Ardent ISD

REVIEW CYCLE
Annual + after major
incident

POLICY CROSS-REFERENCE

CQB FL

records-retention
schedule

acceptable use

Training Sample - Customize Before Use. This document is an instructional artifact for Ardent ISD. It should be aligned to current board policy, administrative procedures, cyber-insurance requirements, records-retention requirements, and advice of district legal counsel before operational use. Legal and reporting requirements can change.

1. Purpose

Ardent ISD classifies information so employees can answer a practical question: **How carefully must I handle this data?** The standard applies to paper and digital information and supplements records-retention, student-records, cybersecurity, and acceptable-use procedures.

2. Classification Levels

Level	Description	Examples	Default handling
Public	Approved for public release	board agendas; published calendar; public website content	Normal public systems
Internal	Routine district information not intended for unrestricted public release	internal procedures; staff directories; draft operational documents	District-approved systems; authenticated access where practical
Confidential	Information protected by law, policy, contract, or legitimate privacy need	student education records; employee personnel records; nonpublic student work; contracts with confidential terms	Access by job need; approved district storage; encrypted transmission; controlled sharing
Restricted / Highly Sensitive	Information whose unauthorized disclosure could create severe identity, safety, legal, or cybersecurity risk	SSNs; government ID numbers; financial account credentials; sensitive health records; authentication secrets; API keys; vulnerability reports; certain security logs/configurations	Strong access controls; encryption; no ordinary email attachments unless protected; strict export limits; enhanced logging; approved transfer methods

Classification does **not** determine records-retention duration. Retention is governed separately by the district's records schedule and legal holds.

3. Handling Matrix

Action	Public	Internal	Confidential	Restricted
Store on district-managed cloud	Yes	Yes	Yes, approved location	Yes, approved restricted location
Store on personal cloud/account	No need; prefer district	No	No	No
Email inside district	Yes	Yes	Minimize attachments; approved sharing preferred	Only using approved protected method
External email	Yes	With business need	Verify recipient; use protected link/encryption	Approved encrypted transfer only
Portable USB/storage	Avoid	Approved if managed	Encrypted only	Encrypted + explicit business need/approval
Local laptop storage	Yes	Managed device	Managed + full-disk encryption	Minimize; managed + encrypted + access controlled
Public generative AI tool	Public information only	Only if approved and nonsensitive	No	No
Print	Yes	Business need	Retrieve immediately; secure disposal	Avoid; if required, controlled custody/shredding

4. Encryption Requirements

Ardent ISD requires encryption appropriate to the data and risk. Examples include:

- full-disk encryption on district-managed laptops that may store Confidential/Restricted information;
- TLS/HTTPS or other approved encryption for data transmitted across untrusted networks;
- encryption for portable storage that contains Confidential/Restricted data;
- approved secure file-transfer methods instead of ordinary email for Restricted data;
- centralized key management for enterprise systems where feasible.

Texas Legal Note on Encryption

Texas Business & Commerce Code §521.002 defines some name-plus-identifier combinations as “sensitive personal information” only when those items are **not encrypted**. However, §521.053's breach definition includes encrypted data if the unauthorized person also has the key needed to decrypt it. Encryption is an important safeguard, but it is not a substitute for incident analysis and legal review.

5. Access Control

- Access is based on job need and least privilege.

- Shared accounts are prohibited unless specifically approved for a technical requirement and compensating controls are documented.
- Privileged accounts are separate from normal day-to-day accounts.
- Access is removed promptly when staff change roles or leave the district.
- Vendor access is time-bounded and reviewed for critical systems.

6. Sharing and Data Minimization

Before sharing Confidential or Restricted information, ask:

1. Does the recipient need this information for an authorized district purpose?
2. Can the same purpose be met with fewer fields or de-identified data?
3. Is the recipient identity verified?
4. Is the transfer method approved for this classification?
5. Is there a contract/DPA or data-sharing agreement when required?
6. Is there a retention/deletion expectation for the recipient?

7. Student Data and Online Services

Texas Education Code Chapter 32 includes protections for “covered information” handled by operators of school-purpose online services and requires reasonable security procedures/practices. FERPA also governs PII from education records. Teachers and staff should not independently create student accounts in unapproved services that collect student PII.

Use Artifact 10 before a new vendor receives protected district data.

8. Generative AI and Sensitive Data

Employees may use district-approved generative AI tools only within the approved data-handling conditions for that tool. Unless a specific district-approved service and agreement permits it, do **not** enter:

- student PII/education records;
- employee PII/personnel information;
- SSNs, financial information, health information;
- passwords, MFA codes, API keys, tokens;
- network diagrams, firewall rules, IP ranges, vulnerability findings;
- incident reports, forensic logs, or cyber-insurance/legal documents;
- vendor-confidential agreements or nonpublic procurement material.

AI-generated cybersecurity or legal advice is a draft for human review, not an authority.

9. Lost Data / Misdelivery / Suspected Disclosure

Report immediately when:

- a message/file was sent to the wrong person;

- a sharing link was made public;
- a device or USB drive is lost;
- a personal account was used to store district data;
- a vendor reports an incident;
- protected information was entered into an unapproved AI or web service.

Do not attempt to conceal or quietly “fix” the event without reporting it. Fast reporting can reduce harm.

10. Secure Disposal

- Follow the district records-retention schedule and legal holds.
- When destruction is authorized, use district-approved secure deletion or physical destruction appropriate to the media.
- Do not donate, recycle, sell, or transfer devices containing district data until sanitization is verified.
- Maintain records of destruction where required.

11. Quick Examples

Scenario	Classification / action
Published school lunch menu	Public
Internal help-desk procedure	Internal
Student grade export	Confidential - district-approved storage and sharing only
HR spreadsheet with employee SSNs	Restricted - minimize export; encrypted controlled transfer; delete when authorized
Firewall vulnerability report	Restricted - security-sensitive; limited distribution
Student names pasted into a public AI chatbot to write parent messages	Prohibited - protected student data must not be entered into unapproved public AI tools
Lost laptop with full-disk encryption	Report immediately; document encryption status/key protection; incident team determines obligations

References

- Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 - Identity Theft Enforcement and Protection Act
- Texas Education Code Chapter 32 - Student Information Protection
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Security: K-12 and Higher Education
- U.S. Department of Education - Model Terms of Service for Online Educational Services
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Texas Requirements

Sources and Legal Reference Points

These artifacts are training samples, not substitutes for localized board policy, district counsel, insurer requirements, or current state/federal guidance.

2026 Texas update: The library reflects the transition of statewide cybersecurity functions to the Texas Cyber Command and its current incident-reporting page. Texas law and agency processes can change; re-verify before operational use.

How the Library Is Grounded

The set treats cybersecurity as a district leadership risk-management function: governance, privacy, vendor review, incident response, communications, legal reporting, recovery, and continuous improvement. It uses the NIST CSF 2.0 functions as an organizing language and incorporates K-12-specific guidance from CISA, CoSN, K12 SIX, the U.S. Department of Education, TASB/TASA, and Texas statutes/agencies.

Primary Sources

- Texas Education Code § 11.175 - School Cybersecurity
- Texas Government Code Chapter 2063 - Texas Cyber Command (see § 2063.302)
- Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 - Identity Theft Enforcement and Protection Act
- Texas Education Code Chapter 32 - Student Information Protection
- Texas Cyber Command - Report a Cybersecurity Incident
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Texas Requirements
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Security Breach Notification and Response
- TASA/TASB - Report on School District Mandates
- NIST Cybersecurity Framework 2.0
- CISA - Protecting Our Future: Cybersecurity for K-12
- CISA - #StopRansomware Guide
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Breach Response Checklist
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Security: K-12 and Higher Education
- U.S. Department of Education - Model Terms of Service for Online Educational Services
- CoSN - K-12 Community Vendor Assessment Tool (K-12CVAT)

- K12 SIX - Cybersecurity Essentials Series and Incident Response Runbook
- Federal Trade Commission - COPPA FAQ: COPPA and Schools

Texas Policy Alignment

TASB public materials identify CQB as the school-district policy area for cybersecurity, with recurring themes of a district cybersecurity plan, designated coordinator, training, and breach/incident notifications. Ardent ISD's samples cross-reference CQB rather than reproducing a TASB model policy. Districts should consult their localized Policy Online manual and current TASB guidance.